

Back facts

Prevention is better than cure

1/3 of accidents at work, resulting in time off work, are back related, rising to over 50% in the care sector.

¾ of handling injuries are strain and sprains, usually the lower back.

50% of reported accidents involve the back.

Most back and related injuries **is preventable**.

Back problems are usually the cumulative effect of small problems building up over time.

Warning signs

- Aching, sharp or dull pain.
- Pain that comes and goes.
- Hot inflamed feeling.
- Tingling or unusual tightness.
- Unusual muscle weakness or fatigue.

See the G.P if

- Passing urine becomes difficult.
- Numbness around genitals or bottom occurs.
- Numbness and/or pins and needles occur down the leg.
- Shooting pains in the legs occur.

DO NOT ignore the warning signs.

Back facts

- Holds you up
- Supports your weight
- Helps you move

Vertebrae ~ are back bones

Discs ~ cushions between the vertebrae

Ligaments ~ hold each vertebrae in place

Muscles ~ attach to the vertebrae to move you around

The spine is a natural S shape

Discs ~ shock absorbing cushions that 'pad out' between vertebrae
Preventing them rubbing together.

Ligaments ~ tough bands of tissue that prevent vertebrae coming out of
Alignment.

Muscles ~ help vertebrae resist pressure and strains cause by the effects of
Of loads bring placed upon them.

Impairing the natural S shape of the spine can severely damage the disks.

Disk damage causes pain.

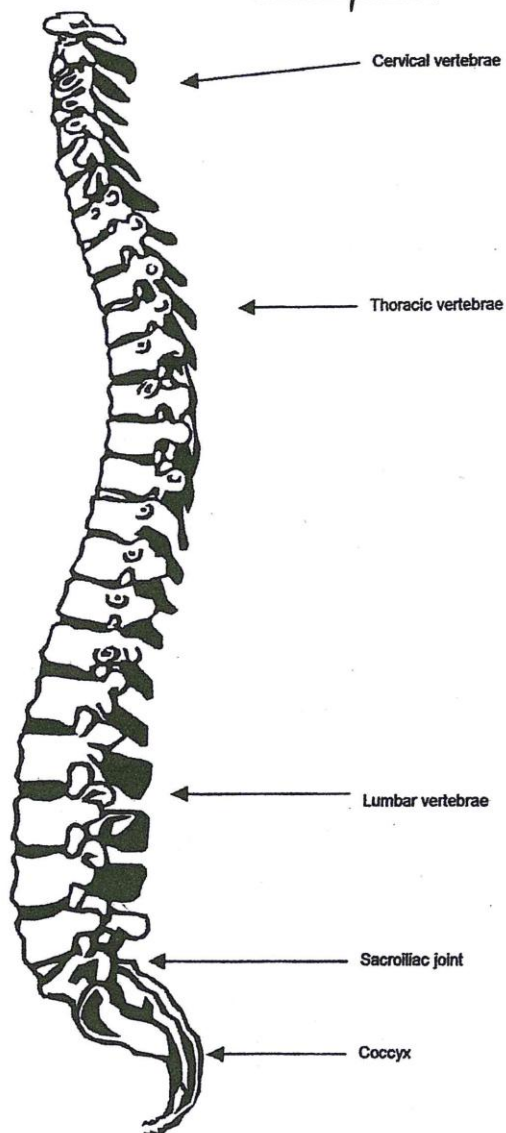
To avoid pain, look after your back.

Remember the body has natural limits- go beyond that and you risk injury.



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The Spine



Note the natural "S" shape of the spine, which:

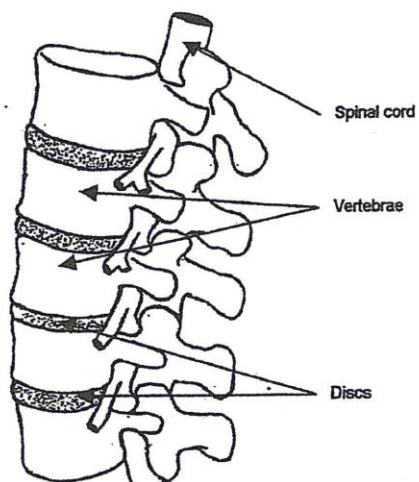
- balances your body
- keeps your head up

What happens if you spoil that "S" shape?

- discs are pressured
- ligaments are strained
- muscles are pulled

How could you spoil the "S" shape?

- slouching
- poor posture
- inappropriate movement
- bad positioning
- excessive movement





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Some causes of injury or harm when moving and handling.

- Twisting and turning
- Bedding and stretching
- Pulling and pushing
- Lifting and carrying and pushing down
- Reaching and repetition
- Sitting and stooping
- Sudden movement
- Posture

Life and life choices:

- Ageing
- Lack of exercise
- Smoking
- Putting on weight
- Footwear
- Poor/ inadequate mattress

Remember

Muscles and ligaments can be damaged through poor lifting, pulling, pushing, twisting etc.

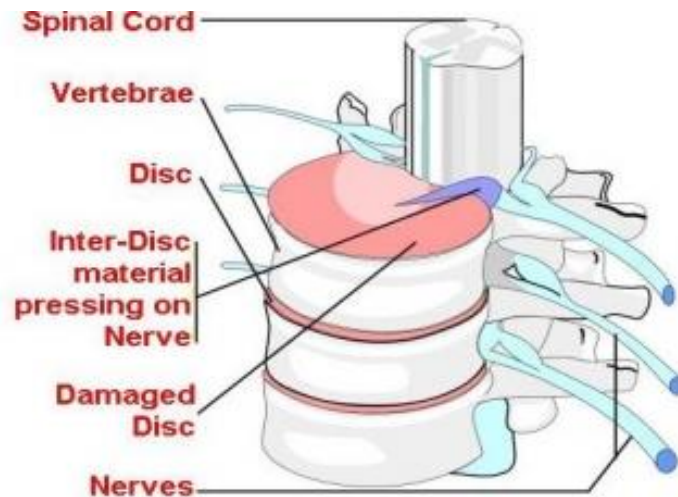
This impairs natural S shape and further strains muscles and ligaments.

Vertebrae becomes misaligned and discs are damaged.

This = **pain**

Take care and move and handle properly.

Wear flat, non slip shoes



Flat shoes and correct placement of feet.

- Hip width apart -1 foot slightly in front of the other.
- Bend the knee – keep your weight over and between your feet.

Muscles and ligaments take 6-8 weeks to heal and recover.

Discs may take even longer.

Heed the warning signs and prevent.

Examples of causes of injuries

Repositioning someone in bed incorrectly
Transferring someone lying down
Using a walking belt without handles

pulling

Use slide sheets, mobile/ceiling hoists, stand aids.

Transferring movements
Making a bed

stretching

Move your feet into position

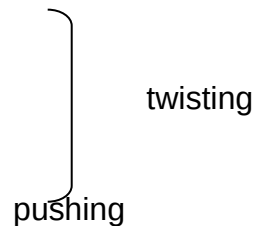
Attempting to lift a fallen person
Loading/ unloading a washing machine

stooping

Place feet correctly and bend the knees

Transferring in a cramped space
Sudden movements causing you loss of balance

Pushing a service user in a wheelchair



Assess the risk and report

Combinations of several of different factors. Using good practice and warning signs.

Handling people more safely

No single correct way to handle, handling training should be to the handling operations.

Adopt and apply the right principles to the relevant problem

- Is the move really necessary
- Avoid lifting
- Stop, think, plan the move – assess the situation
 - the task
 - the individuals capability
 - the load
 - the environment

know your limitations.

- Get help – it isn't a crime
- Check the care plan / handling assessment
- Use equipment to reduce the risk of injury
- Have you enough of the right equipment ?
- Do not use/ do what you have not been trained to
- Get the person to do it for themselves - Independence !
- Communicate with the person being handled
- Communicate with the colleagues involved with the move
- Two carers or more? Nominate a leader

- Stay close to the person (load)
- Try to move them towards you, never away from you
- Spine is a natural “S” shape
- Get into the right position
- Let your body weight and balance do the work, not your back

Get into the correct position

To use the leg muscles not the back

To prevent the back acting as a pivot

To minimize the risk of injury

Getting into position

- Stop, think – plan the move
- Right footwear? Comfortable flat non slip shoes
- Feet a hip’s width apart (balance)
- One foot forward, facing direction of travel
- Other foot slightly back
- Stay close to person (load)
- Knees bent, relaxed
- Use the more powerful leg muscles
- Tummy muscles tightened
- Elbows in
- Chin in
- Spine in its natural “S” shape
- Good grips on the person / load / equipment
- Move – several short moves are better than one big move
- **Do not twist**
- Put down using same principles
- Talk to the person – what you are doing, why, how ,ect
- Smile – it relaxes, reduces fear and perks people up
- Male carers – be sensitive about moving females, ask permission

Team handling

- 1 person must clearly be leader
- Talk to each other via the leader

- Leader talks to the person being handled

Risk assessment

A legal requirement

Prevention is better than cure – not to make extra work

Who knows best – you do – you do it every day

Aims

To avoid moving and handling when not necessary

Circumstances and conditions of service user may change

Observe and report

Practice may also change need updates

Traffic light system

Red, **stop**, handling in particular way.

Orange, **proceed with caution** – need to assist

Green, **Go** – let them get on with it

Risk	general action	stop/caution/go
High	moving and handling Aids must be used.	
Medium	assistance is necessary (one or two staff)	
Low	supervision is required	

The law

- Is not there to find fault
- Provides a framework to assist and assess risk

YOU are the best positioned to identify problems – you deal with them every day.

Main pieces of legislation

Health and safety at work act
Manual handling operation regulations
Provision and use of work equipment regulations
Lifting operations and lifting equipment regulations

They are the responsibilities of both the

Employer and employee

Employer

Assess the risk
Tell employees about relevant risks
Provide safe ways of working
Provide safe and suitable equipment (and maintain it)
Train staff
Keep working environment safe
Protect anyone not in their employment – residents , visitors
Responsibilities are continuous

Employee

Take care of own safety

Be careful no one is harmed by anything I do or did not do

Co-operative with employer

Follow written policies / procedures

Work as trained

Don't misuse things

Report potentially harmful situations

Prevention is better than cure

Avoid moving and handling where possible

If unavoidable – assess the risk

Where possible – remove or reduce

Inform others they may be affected by the risk

Training must be given

To new employees as soon as they start

Update on a periodic basis as circumstances dictate

Wherever something changes

During working hours

In a way they can be applied practically

There is no specific legal maximum or minimum safe weight

Fit the job to the person not the person to the job.